WHAT'S THE NON-PROD PATH?

A question that prevents late-stage project failure.

Why this question matters

Most project delays don’t happen at build time.

They surface during testing, security review, or deployment.

By then, risk is already exposed.

What people think it means

Do we have a non-prod environment?

That’s only the starting point.

What it actually means

How does work move safely *end-to-end* before production?

- Infrastructure
- Code
- Data
- Security
- Access
- Approvals

All connected.

A real non-prod path includes

- Environment readiness (DEV / QA / UAT)
- Infrastructure parity with production
- Network, firewall, and load balancer alignment

It also includes

- Test data that reflects reality
- Access, service accounts, and secrets
- CI/CD paths that actually deploy

WHEN THIS IS MISSING...

- Testing takes longer than planned
- Security findings appear late
- Deployments fail “unexpectedly”
- Audit concerns surface post-release

These aren’t surprises.

They’re upstream gaps.

Why senior PMs ask this early

Because fixing a broken path early
is cheaper than explaining a failure later.

This isn't about control.
It's about system integrity.

Infrastructure projects don’t fail at build time.

They fail when SDLC assumptions are missing upstream.

Systems thinking changes outcomes.

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